



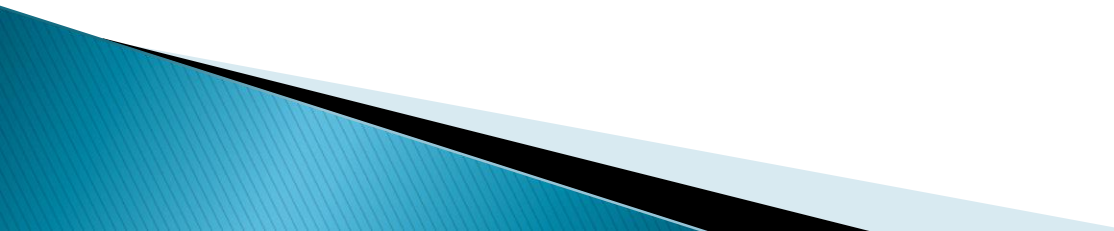
Estonian culture and identity

18.09.2025

Professor Piret Viires (Tallinn)

Erik Kõvamees (Vancouver)

Structure of the Lecture

- ▶ I. Overview of the group works.
 - ▶ II. Self-representations and stereotypes about Estonia.
 - ▶ III. Erik Kõvamees, Estonian identity in diaspora.
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Overview of the group works



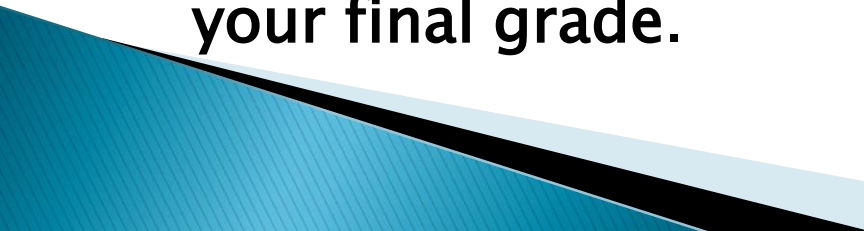
Final seminar

11 December 2025

Group Works

- ▶ Final seminar. Group work on selected texts on Estonian language and culture. 5 groups. Make your choice and form groups in Moodle!
- ▶ Results to be presented in the seminar on 11 December 2025.
- ▶ Choose one group work and register to the group. The limit of one group is **5 students**.
- ▶ You can see the group work descriptions when you click on **"Show descriptions"** (or in the file **"Guidelines for the group work"**).
- ▶ You will see your group members, when you click **"Show members"**
- ▶ The articles for reading for each group work are below in Moodle.
- ▶ Connect your task with the scholarly articles you have read.

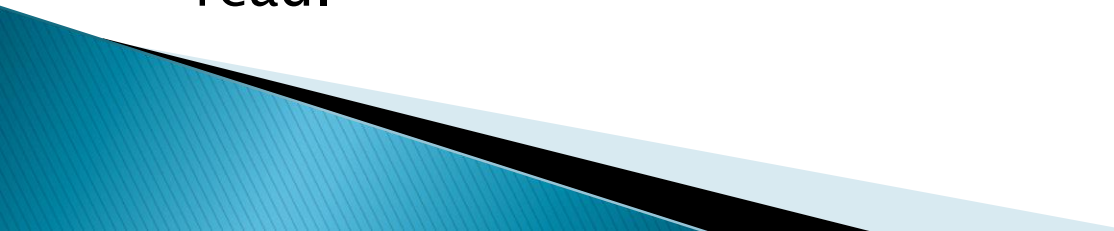
Group Works

- ▶ Display the results of the group work in a PowerPoint presentation and present the results in the seminar on **11 December 2025**.
 - ▶ Choose one or two students among the group who are going to present the work, or you can present it all together.
 - ▶ The time limit for one presentation is **10 minutes**.
 - ▶ The instructors will give short comments about your presentations.
 - ▶ After the presentation upload the PowerPoint slides to Moodle.
 - ▶ The final slide should give the information what were the tasks of different group members.
 - ▶ The group work and presentation will form **30% of your final grade**.
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Group Works

- ▶ **Group Work 1. Languages in Estonia.**
- ▶ Read the following language-related articles (files available in Moodle):
- ▶ *Anna Verschik, Migration, Identity and Language Change. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
- ▶ *Martin Ehala, The Role of Language in Estonian National Identity. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
- ▶ *Marleen Kedars and Anna Verschik (2021), Comparing linguistic landscapes of the old towns of Tallinn and Vilnius. – Anna Verschik (ed.), Multilingual Practices in the Baltic Countries. Tallinn: Tallinn University Press, 144–175.*
- ▶ Photograph 15–20 multilingual signs, advertisements (choose a particular area of Tallinn or compare two different area), information boards and try to analyze them.
- ▶ What languages are used? Are there hybrid forms? What does the order of languages tell us? Is there bilingual language play?
- ▶ Connect your task with the scholarly articles you have read.

Group Works

- ▶ **Group Work 2. Language and Identity**
 - ▶ Read the following language-related articles (files available in Moodle):
 - ▶ *Anna Verschik, Migration, Identity and Language Change. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
 - ▶ *Martin Ehala, The Role of Language in Estonian National Identity. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
 - ▶ *Martin Ehala & Kadri Koreinik (2021) Patterns of individual multilingualism in Estonia, Journal of Baltic Studies, 52:1, 85–102,*
 - ▶ Interview 3–4 Estonian-speaking students or friends: ask them about their mother tongue and identity, the role of other languages in their life.
 - ▶ Connect your task with the scholarly articles you have read.
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Group Works

- ▶ **Group Work 3. The Future of Estonian language.**
- ▶ Read the following language-related articles (files available in Moodle):
- ▶ *Anna Verschik, Migration, Identity and Language Change. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
- ▶ *Martin Ehala, The Role of Language in Estonian National Identity. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
- ▶ *Kristiina Praakli, Changes in Estonian Communities Abroad and Estonian Language Proficiency. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
- ▶ *Review the lecture "Language and identity in Estonia" (Slides of the lecture available in Moodle).*
- ▶ Ask 3–4 Estonian-speakers whether, in their opinion, Estonian is endangered or not and why.
- ▶ Compare popular perception with scholarly perspective and analyze the differences/similarities.
- ▶ Connect your task with the scholarly articles you have read.

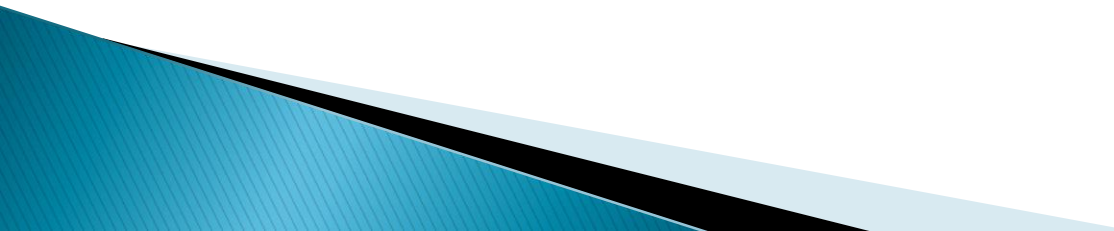
Group Works

- ▶ **Group Work 4. Symbols of Estonian Culture.**
- ▶ Read the following culture-related articles (files available in Moodle):
- ▶ *Marek Tamm, Estonia's Cultural Changes in an Open World. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
- ▶ *Tõnu Viik, Evolving Self. Descriptions of Estonian Culture. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
- ▶ *Eneken Laanes, Transnationalisation of the Estonian Memory Culture. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
- ▶ Photograph at least 5 symbolically relevant (for Estonians) sites in Tallinn (monuments, streets, buildings etc) and try to analyze these sites:
- ▶ What makes them symbolically important? What is their historical background?
- ▶ How do explain their role in Estonian culture?
- ▶ Connect your task with the scholarly articles you have read.

Group Works

- ▶ **Group Work 5. The Cornerstones of Estonian Cultural Identity.**
- ▶ Read the following culture-related articles (files available in Moodle):
- ▶ *Tõnu Viik, Evolving Self. Descriptions of Estonian Culture. Estonian Human Development Report 2016/2017.*
- ▶ *Jüri Talvet, Kalevipoeg, a great European epic. – Estonian Literary Magazine, 2003, nr 17*
- ▶ *Piret Õunapuu. On Estonian folk culture: Pro et contra. Folklore 2014, vol. 58*
- ▶ Interview your Estonian friends, or use Internet resources or course materials available in Moodle.
- ▶ Find 5 works of art (e. g. literary texts, films, musical compositions, visual art, artefacts of traditional culture) or cultural events that could be defined as cornerstones of Estonian cultural identity.
- ▶ Analyze, relying on the scholarly texts, why these works of art / artefacts of traditional culture have achieved such a prominent position in Estonian culture.
- ▶ What is the message of these works of art / artefacts of traditional culture and what does it say about Estonian culture?
- ▶ Connect your task with the scholarly articles you have read.

Questions and support

- ▶ Choose your group by 30 September 2025, contact your group members and start planning.
 - ▶ If you have questions, ask
 - ▶ anna.verschik@tlu.ee – language-related group works
 - ▶ piret.viires@tlu.ee – culture-related group works
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Self-representations and stereotypes about Estonia



Self-representations and stereotypes about Estonia

- ▶ How Estonia is representing itself to the world?
- ▶ Estonian branding:
- ▶ “Brand Estonia helps you introduce Estonia in a way that attracts attention, creates trust and makes you proud. /---/ Together we will create the image of Estonia.”
(brand.estonia.ee)

tere!



This is an overview of Estonia

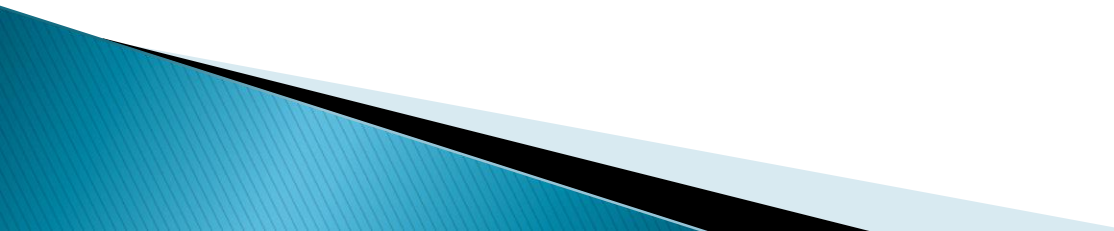
Imagology – Stereotypes

- ▶ Imagology – studies how countries and nations are pictured and perceived.
 - ▶ The focus is on the national stereotypes – pre-set perceptions of the nations.
 - ▶ In imagology the discussion is on images, perceptions, not on the essence of a nation.
 - ▶ Instead of saying “what people are like” the attention has shifted on to how people perceive or envisage others and themselves.
 - ▶ Cultural difference has come to be studied in terms of attitudes and perceptions rather than essences.
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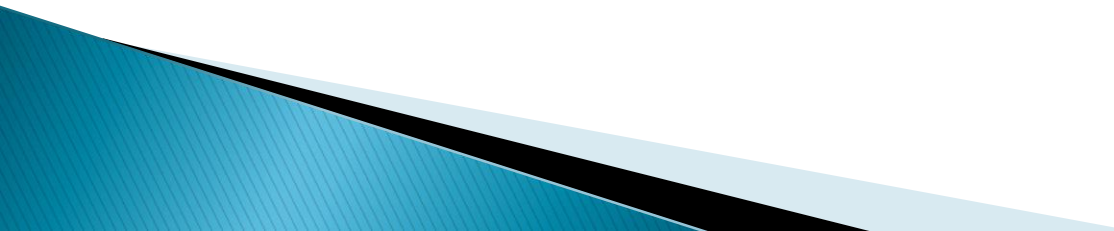
Imagology – Stereotypes

- ▶ The focus is on “national characters”, “ethnotypes” (the characteristics stereotypically attributed to various nationalities).
- ▶ *Studia Imagologica*, edited by Hugo Dyserinck and Joep Leerssen
- ▶ Manfred Beller & Joep Leerssen (eds.) *Imagology. The cultural construction and literary representation of national characters* (2007)
- ▶ Website *Imagologica* <https://imagologica.eu/>

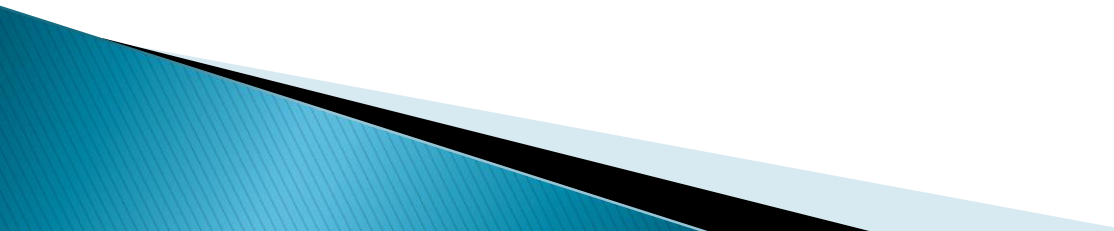
Imagology – Stereotypes

- ▶ Imagology makes a distinction between auto-image and hetero-image:
 - ▶ auto-image marks the attitude towards ones own culture and creation of self-identity
 - ▶ hetero-image marks the attitude towards another culture.
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Stereotypes

- ▶ National stereotypes bring about the so-called wow-effect.
 - ▶ The worn-out understanding (e.g. the French are great lovers, Italians love good food) sounds familiar and thus the familiar feeling is taken for a valid fact.
 - ▶ For example most of the jokes and anecdotes on nations are based on stereotyped perceptions.
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Case of Estonia

- ▶ Self-representations – result of branding, information available on Internet (auto-image)
 - ▶ Stereotypes – prejudices (hetero-image)
 - ▶ Expectations
 - ▶ Truth
 - ▶ Source material: essays of students „What is Estonia for me?“ of previous courses
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Self-representations of Estonia: auto-image

- ▶ The result of Estonia's branding and self-representations:
 - ▶ Small and fast developed country
 - ▶ People love freedom and independence, but don't like violence (Singing Revolution)
 - ▶ Small nation with a unique and beautiful language
 - ▶ Beautiful untouched nature, plenty of woods
 - ▶ Good air quality
 - ▶ Quiet
 - ▶ Peace and space for everyone
 - ▶ Estonians love nature and healthy lifestyle
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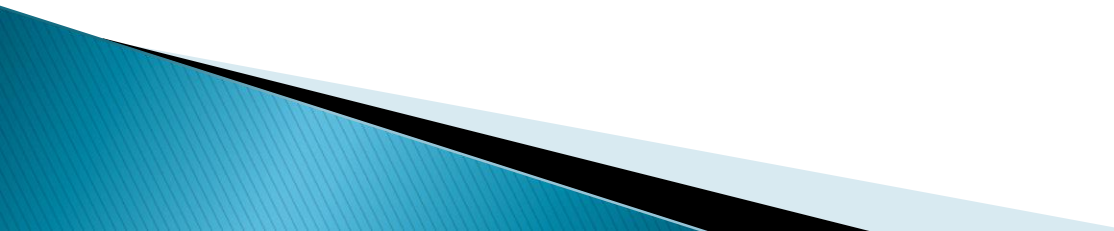
Self-representations of Estonia: auto-image

- ▶ E-Estonia, free wifi everywhere
 - ▶ Digital identities, digital citizenship
 - ▶ Estonians don't talk much, but work hard, are reliable and keep their promises
 - ▶ Family values and children are important
 - ▶ Estonians value their language, culture and love to sing
 - ▶ Estonians are strong and independent, think with their own minds
 - ▶ Estonia is a small, but beautiful and technologically highly developed country.
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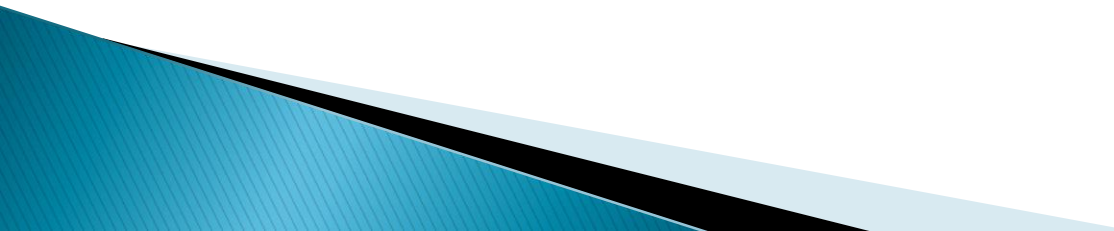
Stereotypes of Estonia: hetero-image

- ▶ Examples from essays „What is Estonia for me?“
- ▶ „Nobody knows where Estonia is“
- ▶ „I started to Google“
- ▶ „I had to look it up on the map“
- ▶ „Estonia was one big blank space for me“
- ▶ „Tiny country in Northern–Eastern Europe that almost no one had heard about“
- ▶ “A country somewhere far in the north”
- ▶ “Maybe in Russia?”
- ▶ „A lot of people did not know where Tallinn is located and that it is the capital of Estonia“
- ▶ „My family and friends were frightened“

Stereotypes of Estonia: hetero-image

- ▶ Unknown place, somewhere far away
 - ▶ Dark and cold
 - ▶ Winter and snow
 - ▶ Post-communist country
 - ▶ Poor and undeveloped country
 - ▶ Cheap
 - ▶ People of Estonia are cold, hostile, don't talk neither smile
 - ▶ Hard for a foreigner to live here.
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Expectations

- ▶ Expectations were formed from the combination of Estonian self-representations (auto-images) and stereotypes about Estonia (hetero-images)
 - ▶ Stereotypes and self-representations were remarkably opposite
 - ▶ Most of the students were curious – wanted to know more and travelled here.
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Truth

Neither self-representations nor stereotypes were totally truthful

Self-representations	Truth
Small and fast developed country	Basically true, but there are several people who are not doing so well; the state support for them is minimal (e.g. elderly retired people) or salaries are low; gender pay gap
E-Estonia, free wifi everywhere, digital technology	Wifi is not always everywhere; some technological achievements are not so perfect (however most of Estonia is covered with mobile data)
Estonians love nature and healthy lifestyle	The lifestyle is not so healthy, alcohol is a great problem in Estonia But the air quality is very clean and it is quiet
Family values and children are important	A lot of broken families and single parents

Truth

Neither self-representations nor stereotypes were totally truthful

Stereotype	Truth
Dark and cold	Warm and sunny summer days
Poor and undeveloped country	Mostly well-doing and fast developed country (however there are also people who are not doing so well) Streets are clean
Cheap	Not so cheap at all
People of Estonia are cold, hostile, don't talk neither smile	People are mostly friendly and helpful (there are exceptions)

Conclusions

- ▶ You must not trust stereotypes
- ▶ You must not trust self-representations and country branding either
- ▶ The only truth is this what you experience yourself living here in Estonia

More about the role of culture in constructing
Estonian self-representations
and national identity –
in the lecture on 13 November 2025
and in the seminar on 27 November 2025

Aitäh!

